Chain of Custody

Law enforcement can request toxicology specimens for forensic or legal reasons. The most common tests are breath and blood alcohol levels, while other tests include urine drug screens and blood specimens for drug analysis. Blood specimens can be collected as evidence for legal proceedings. Forensic blood samples can also be drawn for DNA analysis or paternity testing, which must be secured to prevent tampering, misidentification, or interference with the test results.

A chain of custody refers to the process that guarantees the integrity of the specimen from the time of collection to the time the test results are published. This process is used to provide documentation of the history of the specimen. This documentation serves three main purposes: to ask relevant questions regarding the evidence of the analytic laboratory, provide a record of the chain of custody, and document that the evidence was only handled by approved personnel and was tampered with before analysis. The documents should include the initials and name of the individuals who collect the specimen, the name of the person who tests or transports the specimen, the date of collection or transfer, the name of the employer or agency, a specimen number, the patient or employee name, and short description of the specimen. Some facilities provide collection kits with all the items required to collect specimens. Therefore, the certified phlebotomist should be familiar with the chain of custody within the facility. A certified phlebotomist may be required to testify in legal proceedings if they are named within the chain of custody.